

Pathwork Guide Lecture No. 139
An Unedited Lecture
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DEADENING OF THE LIVE-CENTER THROUGH MISINTERPRETATION OF REALITY

Greetings, my dearest, dearest friends. Blessings for everyone of you. Blessed be this evening. May your understanding of this lecture open your mind and your vision so that you all advance a further step in your self-realization.

It seems one of the most difficult of accomplishments is to fully understand the present situation, how it is a direct result of the individual. Just because this understanding is so immediate and so near, it seems so distant. Just because it is so closely available and so easy, it seems to require so much effort and struggle to obtain it. Once one discovers the knack of it, it is so easy, so natural, and it becomes obvious that it has been "here" all along. Even those of my friends who are involved in this pathwork for a considerable time do still overlook and fail to see themselves as they are. And they do not understand their present situation, what it means in terms of their own innermost being, because the mechanism of escape often is so deeply entrenched that one is inclined to overlook that which is most significant. This lecture, once again, is destined to shake you out of it, to make you more aware, to awaken you to yourself and to your immediate outer situation.

Whenever man finds himself in a situation that is not desirable, that leaves him unfulfilled in any way, his usually vague discontent causes him to strive for another situation. A clear-cut goal directedness and precise concept of a better way of life can succeed only when the present situation, with its lack, is totally understood. Striving into a different situation when the present situation is not fully understood must result in failure and frustration.

How can the present situation be fully understood, my friends? It can only be done, in the first place, by becoming fully aware of what you really miss. It must be put into words stating precisely what you would want different in your life. This must be the first awareness. The second awareness must be the extent to which you suffer from what you miss. For that too is often pushed aside and not really acknowledged. How much do you really miss what you miss? Do not glibly content yourself with a vague, general acknowledgment. The full intensity of partly repressed longings and frustrations must be aired out. The third awareness, in this respect, must be a total comprehension of your present situation. And that of course means, after the above acknowledgments, how you come about enduring your present situation. It is essential that you profoundly understand how the present situation is a direct outcome of yourself -- how it is so.

Of course, I have discussed this many times in the past. If I repeat it now, it is not only in connection with the lecture to follow but also because I see all around among my friends, despite the good progress, that this is still vastly overlooked. Therefore I invite all of you to follow through this simple formula and give your total attention to what you feel right now, what you experience right now, and why this is so. How is your outer situation a symbolic representation of your inner

state of being? When you finally find and connect the fact that your outer state, no matter how undesirable it may be, is exactly a result of what you are, and what you think, and what you feel, and what you want, and when you subsequently understand that your outer situation cannot be any different in view of what you think, feel, want, and how you act, react, and what your attitude is; when you deeply know that it cannot be any different, then you have totally exploited, assimilated, and comprehended your present now, your total situation. This comprehension, this situation, this analyzing in depth results in knowing that any present situation must be as it is as a direct link to the inner being. It must be found that the present situation is an exact result of the sum total of the personality. This includes, of course, also the favorable circumstances. When you overlook and neglect the enjoyment of all the good circumstances in your life, you must be commensurately unaware of your values. As you learn, each moment, to value, appreciate, and enjoy what life offers you, you must simultaneously become aware of the good in you, your values and assets. This will give you greater strength to come out of vicious circles and self-generating negative attitudes and will make more realistic the understanding of the undesirable situation as it relates to your inner personality. You will gain a more rounded picture of the total situation of your person and, respectively, of your life.

So long as you are vague and hazy about what you miss and so long as you deny what you miss, that long you cannot possibly understand your life. Understanding one's life in this fashion is the key to changing it into a more desirable and fulfilling way.

Most of my friends on this path have had occasion, here and there, to understand their life and themselves as one unit in the way mentioned here. These moments are always deep experiences of the reality of being, of vibrant aliveness, of light and truth. It seems so difficult just because it is so immediate and so near. It seems so much easier to wish for something vaguely different, or even precisely different, in discontent and tense struggle, in a mood of complaining resentment and self-pity, while one ignores (a) the intensity of the real longing, (b) the presence of reservations to this real longing, (c) their "reasons," (d) the consequent thoughts, feelings, emanations, attitudes in inner and outer behavior, (e) how these must affect others and thereby create the present situation. It is also often overlooked that the present situation is a result of many years of deeply entrenched patterns of thinking, acting, and feeling and cannot change instantly after some recognitions have been made. These recognitions dilute again in effect when they do not bring an immediate result. This instant expectancy contains the identical qualities of childish demands from life, of angry refusal to cooperate with life's laws, which are most certainly contained in the reasons for the unfulfillment itself. This also causes the individual to overlook the good he has, and he fails to enjoy and appreciate it.

When one ignores the oneness between one's innermost self and one's outer situation, it is always because one runs away from oneself. One does not really and totally want to see oneself as one is -- but only in a limited way and with reservations. Ask yourself, all of you, do you truly wish to see yourself totally, as you are? Do you cultivate such aim by expressing this desire, particularly in moments of discontent and disharmony? Or are you quick with glibly furnishing outer "explanations" for your disharmony? Or do you, perhaps, generally admit that it must be in you, because you know enough about the truth of these matters, but let it go at that, without the willingness to really look? The simple formula of expressing the deep and full intention and desire to see the full truth about oneself at all times is still not sufficiently used. So much greater liberation

could exist if this were followed through in greater detail and with more attention of the self to the immediate situation.

The reasons for the strong tendency to escape from the self -- and therefore inevitably from life, with all its good possibilities -- are manifold. In the course of these lectures, we have discussed many of the possible motives and reasons for escape. Let us now pay specific attention to one aspect that in the past I have only generally and vaguely touched upon for the simple reason that none of my friends were quite ready to face this aspect in themselves. It could only be discussed and contemplated in very general terms. The last few months have brought considerable progress for a number of my friends, and therefore what I have to say now can be accepted and looked at by many of you. A few of you have already come to see this, while others are still struggling so very much against this aspect in themselves.

The aspect that I want to discuss is not just mere hostility. Hostility has become too vague a term. It has become almost meaningless in its repeated use. Let us deliberately be as crass as possible. In most human beings -- in some more and in some less -- there exist elements of cruelty. This cruelty is hard to face. But when you do face it, then relief and liberation must follow because nothing further bars the way to being totally in truth with yourself. As long as the cruelty within yourself is not fully faced, as long as you run away from it, you cannot be clear and comfortable, unafraid and relaxed about yourself. You cannot be good friends with yourself. You can be good friends with yourself when you accept, acknowledge, understand, and work, openly and candidly, on these cruel aspects even before you could totally eliminate them. But as long as you still struggle against cruelty in the wrong and self-defeating way, namely by denial and hiding, you must be in constant friction with yourself and therefore inevitably with life and with others. You cannot be comfortable in your own skin; therefore life and yourself will feel wrong; problems will appear without solutions. Solutions can appear on the horizon only in exact proportion as you face that in you which you fear most -- and that is usually cruelty. You cannot think of anything worse in you. Nothing could frighten you more than this aspect in yourself. It is a reliable gauge to determine the still unrecognized existence of cruelty within yourself when you consider the amount of fear you have left -- fear of other people (generally or of specific ones), fear of life, fear of death, fear of the unknown. The more you are afraid of ruthlessness and separateness, of rejection and humiliation, of physical and mental cruelty, the more must these exact same aspects slumber within your self, as yet not fully acknowledged. As long as this is the case -- regardless of how large or small these unrecognized aspects are -- you will be in conflict. You will run from those areas in your life which appear difficult and uncomfortable. And just because they are unpleasant for you now, they harbor the very key you need, if only you would stop running, if you would really look at yourself and see that you run from yourself by avoiding certain outer and inner situations, and see why you do so. In these instances lies the secret you are still unwilling to unveil in spite of all your good efforts. Yet, as long as you cannot meet yourself and others without reservations, you cannot possibly fulfill yourself. It means that you want to continue deceiving yourself by avoiding these aspects. You may vaguely feel something like it, but there is a great difference between that and really looking into it.

He who has begun to do so must already have overcome the worst. This is not necessarily a question of time, of how long one has been in this pathwork -- not by any means.

Let us now discuss why cruelty exists. After having acknowledged its existence, what then? Before returning to the answer to this question, I shall mention that innermost center of man which

activates him with all he needs in order to live productively. This live-center furnishes him with energy, with life force, with wisdom, with vision, with solutions, with love and harmony. This live-center exists deep within, in every individual. In a young person, in a child, it manifests as a very vulnerable spot. Its very aliveness comes forth from a tender, soft, and vulnerable center. When children are hurt and puzzled and when they misunderstand the happenings around them, they proceed to toughen this vulnerable spot to defend themselves against its soft openness. By various mechanics which are thereby instituted, the live-center becomes more and more overlaid, hidden, and covered by tough substances. Without an adult and realistic understanding -- that is, a mature ego -- the child cannot handle this soft, malleable live-center, in which the most powerful, creative, and intelligent forces are contained. For its own protection, it must separate this life center from its consciousness. However, when the child grows into an adult, when the ego becomes mature, this separation becomes an unfortunate handicap. The individual lives in a crippled way, leaving out the best and most reliable aspect of his whole being. Only when he proceeds to uncover it again and integrate it with the adult ego does the personality become whole and equipped to handle life.

The existence of this bare, vulnerable life center can be determined not only by remembering childhood with its strong emotions and deep experiencing (positive and negative), but when you truly observe yourself, you cannot fail to become conscious of moments when this vulnerable spot is here. You can further observe how you then proceed to make it invulnerable. In other words, you continue to use the process that was instituted in childhood but which now operates greatly to your detriment, for it is the wrong way to protect yourself and to cope best with life. The means to inactivate the live-center are various: by separating and withdrawing; by toughening yourself; by numbing your feelings; by denial of your real feelings and substituting counterfeit feelings; and also by cruelty. All these measures serve to make the vulnerable spot within you invulnerable because this seems the only "safe" way. You overlook and ignore the fact that the very vulnerability is the material, as it were, with which to govern your life in the most dynamic and fruitful way. For this vulnerable spot is the life center out of which all energy and wisdom is derived. It is that in you which makes it possible to fully experience and enjoy, to have and give pleasure. The potent energy, deriving from this live-center, can be utilized in a most constructive and meaningful way in the realization that this live-center must become a conscious aspect to be integrated with the ego. If this is hindered due to misunderstanding and ignorance, the energy will turn destructive, the power inverted, and the result must be chaos, separation, disintegration, confusion, suffering, and an inner division and numbness that makes life appear difficult, ugly, removed, and senseless.

The activation of your real self, or the divine center, is not something that you gain from the outside or even from within yourself as something far away you have not yet experienced. There are many occasions when you vaguely and hazily experience it -- even in those occasions of natural, unexaggerated sadness. But you make sure to deny this experience because you do not know how to cope with it, how to handle it; so you flatten this experience, you prohibit the deeper and richer dimensions that come from your innermost center.

As long as this inner center is still in the condition it was in when you were a child, it is not yet in a position to handle life. The inner wisdom contained in the live-center begins to manifest only after integration with the ego occurs. In the child state, the inner center is just alive, full of feeling, energy, and capacities for experience, for pleasure, as well as for yet unutilized potentials of creativity and intelligence. What you must learn to do now is to (1) observe the existence of the live-center, (2) observe the mechanics by which you discourage its manifestations and toughen the vulnerable

spot; (3) deliberately stop doing the latter and allow its unfoldment. Through appropriate meditations, integration between this live-center and the ego will take place so that its substance will become strong and resilient without losing its soft aliveness.

You find yourself in the predicament of possessing an adult ego with all its faculties intact, but separated from that vulnerable live-center. This vulnerable live-center is separated from your ego faculties, from your wakeful consciousness -- and that is your problem.

The more the live-center is unrealistically and inadequately "defended" and blocked, denied and covered up, the more do aspects come into being which man must be ashamed of and feel guilty for. One of the severest forms is that of cruel impulses. Cruelty will truly cease in the depth of the human soul, not only in action and conscious thoughts but in the unconscious emotions, when the live-center is not denied and hindered, but recognized, observed, allowed to function. The intense feelings of this live-center can then be compared with reality, as it unfolds. The ego faculties will help in the process; reason and intelligence will adjust imbalances and deviation from reality. But when reason is used to deny the depth, scope, and richness of feelings as they manifest from the live-center, the human personality cripples itself and brings itself out of balance. Bring the manifestation of the live-center, with its vulnerability, its strength of feelings, together with your adult understanding, with your ego faculties.

Cruelty can exist only as a result of a separation between this live-center and the ego. To put it in more practical terms, cruelty exists because reality is misinterpreted, which causes the individual further to inactivate the live-center. It is not only the child who misinterprets happenings around himself. Where the child has done that, this is precisely where the adult continues to do so right now unless and until this has been found and corrected. All of you, in the areas of your difficulties, go on misinterpreting reality. You do not perceive what goes on around you, you do not see things the way they really are, but misunderstand them.

How can you discover such misunderstanding? -- only when you acknowledge to yourself first what it is that you actually believe, then understand and interpret what it means. This applies to anything that makes you feel disharmonious. Ask yourself what is your interpretation of that which others feel and think about you.

Let us take a practical example to make this more understandable. A common example is that you feel slighted, discriminated against, rejected. As a rule, you admit this only vaguely. You may even admit these words, but you do not fully admit and acknowledge to what extent you feel this, and why you feel this, and what makes you believe that your feelings are justified and appropriate. Then you can go to the next step and ask yourself, "Is this real, or do I just believe it? Could it be otherwise?" Even when you do admit to feeling rejected, you usually let it go at that, and you live in a fog, in a haze in which it is not fully examined whether or not it is real. You may somehow and vaguely say that perhaps it is not real, but then there is another level which you do believe is real, and this level is not totally faced and examined.

Cruelty, which is the greatest stumbling block to self-facing, to living in the dynamic, adventurous beauty of each now, and which is the greatest factor in the running away from yourself, is ultimately a result of misinterpreting reality. You cannot interpret reality accurately as long as you do not clearly and precisely formulate what it is that you believe, how you interpret happenings

which seem to call for hurt and defenses, and as long as you do not consider the possibility that it could be different from the way you believe.

I have discussed here several points which, in your work, must be combined.

Point No. 1: An undesirable situation, a lack of fulfillment, an emptiness cannot be eliminated and changed into a more desirable condition unless you understand the present situation in the sense that it cannot be different because you fully recognize that the cause is in you.

Point No. 2: Let us separate the admission of the lack, which is the first point, from the second one, which is the recognition of what in you caused it, so that you deeply experience the oneness between your self and your life situation.

Point No. 3: The cruel aspects in you represent the main reasons for all resistance and fear of self-facing. Often these cruel aspects can be found only when one acknowledges one's fear. Do not forget the important correlation between fear of others or any outer facet of life and the fear of your unrecognized cruelty. If you are free from cruelty, you cannot ever fear others.

Point No. 4: Establish in what moment the live-center is bare, but bare as in the vulnerable state of a child which has not yet integrated these energies and feelings with the ego faculties. When this integration takes place, the vulnerable live-center is no longer vulnerable in a negative, dangerous, or debilitating way, but in a good, most wonderful way. It is flexible, alive, vibrant, and full of strong, wonderful feelings without which no pleasure, no joy, no happiness can exist. The tremendous strength and intelligence contained in this vulnerable spot will govern all your actions and attitudes. It will cause thoughts and emotions which must bear fruit all around you. It will induce you to be totally constructive in all you do. You will want to give your best and total attention to everything you experience, to all your undertakings. Nothing will be done halfheartedly, with half attention or with divided motives; therefore the outcome will be more and more desirable and fulfilling. There is no strain in this attention. You will be carried by a sweeping, marvelous strength. Instead of covering up the vulnerable spot, you will bring it out. Instead of shying away from the feelings in this vulnerable spot, you will widen the area of aliveness, but strengthen it with a new resiliency which comes from understanding reality and correctly interpreting what goes on in you and in others.

When this vulnerable spot is integrated with the ego, even in the beginning stages of this, then your goal is accomplished in this particular respect of your evolutionary process. You have to go through these points I have indicated. It is necessary to connect your fears with your own unacknowledged cruelty. Discover how this cruelty is a result of misinterpretation. Question yourself closely as to why you have these cruel impulses. As you do so, acknowledge what hurts you, what you would want different, what you believe happens from others to you, from life to you. As you put this precisely into words, then take the next step. Ask yourself if you are in reality when you believe thus and thus.

Now, my friends, this lecture must not remain a theoretical study. To the extent that you use this for yourself, will you make it a reality. Some of you have begun to do so in your personal pathwork. Others have not yet begun with this particular phase. But I do expect, if not tonight, then in the following question-and-answer period, that you present me with such problems. For

instance, you must first come to certain recognitions in this respect when you begin by expressing exactly what hurts you and why. You might begin from there with your questions, and I may help you further. Let us consider together whether or not this hurt is justified. Is it really the way you feel it to be? The moment you can ask this question as to the reality of your experiencing slight and hurt, you have a firm foundation from which to proceed. As long as you cannot ask yourself this question because you do not yet know that you feel it, you have to seek the proper way in your momentary phase of the pathwork.

Some of you may be aware of the cruelty, even if but vaguely. Then you can proceed from there. Some may be very much aware of their fears, but are separated from the other side of the fear coin, namely the cruel impulses in themselves. Others may be acutely aware of their unfulfillments, of any type of undesirable present situation, but have not yet connected this with their own innermost causes. Still others may have accomplished this to some degree but overlook the rare instances when their true vulnerable spot comes to the fore, and they have not yet observed how they manage to get away from it, how they cover it up, harden, or numb it in one fashion or another. All these possibilities exist now for your further work. Some of you have awareness of one or of some of these aspects but not of the others; but none of you is aware of all these aspects. May all of you bring these points together, not as thought-understanding but as deeply felt experience. This indeed will give you courage and liberation. None of these aspects is equally strong in everyone. For example, with some of my friends, the area of their illusion and misinterpretation of reality is relatively small. They are rational and real in many areas, while their misinterpretation of reality applies only to certain areas, and these areas may be so hidden and so vague, so subtle and elusive that it is difficult to ascertain. Just because they are apparently so much in reality, it is easy to overlook where they are not and to what extent they are not. In a certain way, these friends have a more difficult time to resolve this problem than those friends who are overtly, obviously, and even on an intellectual level in an illusion or delusion, although the latter may suffer more acutely until they reach the point of questioning their interpretation of happenings and reactions of other people to themselves. And then there are those who believe that they are so very reasonable, rational, and realistic, yet they are deluded even about that.

This material I give you here can indeed be a major tool for all of you. Now, do you have any questions regarding this topic?

QUESTION: I have found this cruelty in me in connection with revenge. I also feel cruelty by isolation and withdrawal (punishing others with it). Now, in spite of having found this, I feel that I cannot give it up, I must hang on to it. Can you help me to go on from here?

ANSWER: Yes. Actually what I said in this lecture is an answer. Your particular key now is to ask yourself why you feel cruel. What do you believe is done to you? What do you expect might be done to you? What do you expect of the other person? Why do you believe the other person is acting or has acted or might act in the way that induces the cruel impulses in you. Acknowledge precisely what it is that you believe. Then the next step must be to ask, "Is it real, or do I only believe it to be so?"

QUESTION: To me, it seems real.

ANSWER: Of course. That is exactly what I mean. Because it does seem real, you seem to need cruelty. You have always let it go on the assumption that it is real. Now, you must open yourself to the possibility that it might not be as you believe. You must consider the possibility that it might be different than you thought. That must be your next step in this respect. As long as you let it go at "This is the way I feel it," in a vague attitude of "Perhaps it is not so, but to me it seems real," without going to the consequences of such an implication, you will remain stuck. When you want to see the truth above all else and reach for it, it will come to you. As long as you let it remain in this hazy climate, you must hold on to the cruelty. The cruelty will be your precarious pleasure. The pleasure will cease when you understand the true facts, and this can only happen when you want to do so and consider new horizons and possibilities that you had never thought about -- when you specifically ask the question, "Are the circumstances, the desires of the other person, the facts really the way I feel it, or might I be mistaken? If it is different, if the reality is different from the way I think and feel it, I would like to see that reality. I open myself up for that reality. I do not commit or obligate myself to anything except that I want to see the truth." Then truth must come, and truth must remove conflict and suffering. That is the way.

QUESTION: I am extremely aware of cruelty and vulnerability in myself. My feelings are so strong when I feel slighted that I feel the desire to kill those who seem to slight me. Yet, I also sense that my reactions may be exaggerated. What should I do about this now that I have become aware of it?

ANSWER: Again, an exact answer can be found in this lecture. But I wish also to answer you personally here. I said before that with some people the areas of their unrealistic understanding is relatively small, while with others it is much more obvious. You belong undoubtedly to the latter category. This is a two-edged thing because due to this unreality, to your unreal perceptions, you suffer more while you are in it, but, on the other hand, it is so crass that you will have an easier time to discover the unreality and find the way out of the illusion. There you have an exact example of what I demonstrated in this lecture. It is wonderful that it is open this much and that, in the short time of your work, it has come out so strongly. Your vulnerability is also still relatively accessible. You think you defend it by separating it from your ego and trying to numb it by cruelty. On the other hand, cruelty is also generated by your misinterpretation of reality. This is extremely strong and obvious, therefore rather easy to determine once you begin to question it and consider the possibility in a serious way. What you believe people feel and think and what they actually feel and think, what you believe they are and what they actually are, is very, very different. Think, every day, my friend, wherein you feel you were insulted, slighted, rejected, discriminated again. Put it down in writing, every single instant. I want you to do this every day. When you do this for a while, only for a few weeks or even for a few days, you will see to what extent, almost all the time that you are in contact with people, you at least anticipate rejection and discrimination, slight and disapproval. And very often you think it already has happened, while in reality nothing could be further from the truth. Now, when you begin to ask yourself whether your feelings are true and commensurate with what actually takes place, and when you will want to see what is true as possibly opposed to what you heretofore believed, you must begin to experience genuine and lasting relief. I want you to work along these lines by yourself and also in conjunction with your group. Ask yourself what you believe the other group members feel about you. When you bring it out, compare it with their actual reactions to you. Then also learn what is behind their reactions and why they feel what they feel. Your entire aim must now be to discover what actually is and how it differs from what you think is true. Then you will not need to toughen the vulnerable spot, which is the essence of the real

live-center without which you cannot successfully live. When you formulate precisely what you think others feel about you and when you then, with equal precision, formulate the possibility that you might be mistaken and contemplate other alternatives, a new world will open for you -- a free world in which you can live without fear, a world of light in which you need not be isolated. Now you feel the whole world is against you. Since you feel the whole world is against you, out to harm and slight you, to reject and humiliate you, you must toughen yourself. Cruelty is almost the only weapon with which to defend yourself against such a world. Therefore you must hang on to it. But when you begin to see that this is not so, you will not need the cruelty, you will be relaxed and light because the world will no longer be your enemy. Other people will no longer be your enemies. Observe yourself now, for instance. When you walk along in the street, observe the subtle and yet distinct feeling of how you perceive the strangers around you, how you perceive that they are all your enemies. Then ask yourself, "Is this true? Are they really my enemies, or may it be different? Might they feel similar to the way I feel -- frightened and lost? And when they are angry, maybe they hit out as I do, at the idea that everyone else is their enemy?" Millions of people pass each other by, day in and day out, each feeling he is singled out to be persecuted. This is often a subtle, not even detectable feeling, but it, nevertheless, is there. Once it is brought out into awareness, you can begin to question it as to its accuracy of perception. You can thus find the way back to reality, hence to truth and light, into a world which is wonderful, not frightening.

My dearest friends, may this lecture bring forth in you all that is healthy, creative, constructive, and real. You will find it immediately "behind" that vulnerable live-center once you allow its first manifestations of initially disquieting emotions to reach your surface awareness. Go through this, and see what will then manifest, especially when your consciousness reaches for this possibility. The constant blessings given unto you combine with this power within you and fill you from within yourself. Be in peace. Be in God!

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The Pathwork® Foundation
PO Box 6010
Charlottesville, VA 22906-6010, USA
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